

As the Government stonewalls requests from historians and RTI activists, it's time to re-examine this paranoid vigilance of our shared past

TOP SECRET

of books on the subcontinent.

Taken aback by the poor flow of records after a 25-year lock-in period, Cabinet Secretary K.M. Chandrasekhar, after a visit to the NAI, had asked all departments to appoint a joint secretary-level officer as Chief Records Officer to maintain an in-house record office and transfer the requisite files to the NAI. Nothing much has changed still.

Anyone venturing to seek details of the 1971 War will end up with loose ends. Recent reports suggest that most of the official records of the War that created Bangladesh have been destroyed, including those on the Mukti Bahini—the Bangladesh freedom fighters. “For an outsider, the papers relating to the Indo-Pakistan War exist. In theory we know they are with the Army. But they are really being destroyed,” says historian Dilip Simeon.

The Sharm el-Sheikh affair explains in a nutshell the story of bureaucratic belligerence. When the MEA was faced with an RTI query seeking information on the joint declaration, at first it refused to respond. Then the applicant, RTI activist Subash Aggarwal, sought the intervention of the Central Information Commission (CIC). A. Ramu, under secretary in the

RAMACHANDRA GUHA

Historian and Author
of *India After Gandhi*



“Indira Gandhi's official correspondence, as prime minister, has not been shown to anyone outside the family. That these papers are not available to scholars is possibly illegal.”

PATRICK FRENCH

Author of *Liberty Or Death: India's Journey To Independence and Division*



“There is no distinction between a politician's private papers and the government's papers. When it comes to research, it's a matter of luck whether you find what you need.”

Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran division of the MEA, told the Commission that the ministry does not have any information pertaining to names of officers who drafted the joint statement and its file notings. In order to verify the submission made by the MEA, the CIC asked the ministry to produce the file. After several reminders, the MEA claimed that there are no file notings connected to the decision taken “as the joint statement issued after such meetings encapsulate the mutually agreed substance of discussion between the leaders during such meetings”. Since the MEA denied the existence of file notings, the Commission said that complainant may be allowed to inspect all relevant records to locate the information. Last month, the MEA moved the Delhi High Court against the CIC decision.

There is no respite even on records which are decades old. Shastri's 19-month tenure as a prime minister was an off-colour interlude tucked between

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